

MICHAEL HEALY EDIT

Michael Healy, Shadow Tourism Minister Queensland Government. Michael, welcome to the Travel Radio Australia. And thank you enormously and it is great to be here.

I know this show goes all over the world and you do a great job so I really do appreciate the opportunity to have a chat. Thanks Michael. Now tourism in Queensland is just such a strong industry.

People come from all over the world to see things like the reef, Brisbane, the Gold Coast, the Sunshine Coast. It's a tremendous area and not just those places I mentioned, Cairns on the coast, there's a whole inland things to discover too, right? Correct, that is correct. And look, tourism is a multi-billion dollar industry, not just for Australia but obviously also for Queensland.

And we are the only state in the Commonwealth and the only place in the world where you've got two world heritage listed assets, side by side being the Great Barrier Reef and the world listed. And ancient rainforests up in the Daintree which is all in far north Queensland but down here in Gladstone and the surrounds we have some spectacular environments. We've got some fantastic reef.

People in regional Queensland do a fantastic job promoting their own destinations. They know how important. The drive market's really big.

The drive market in Australia which is domestic market and we're seeing more and more people who are retiring. They're getting in their cars and they're hitching up their caravans and they're driving in regional Queensland is doing extremely well out of it and also out in the west. And what happens is, like we're seeing here in Gladstone, I had a meeting this morning with the chairman of the tourism organisation and they want to build more tourism assets.

They want to build more accommodation. They won't realise how important caravan parks are so knowing those things is really important. But having, I mean the weather's fantastic.

Look at this, here we are tonight. We're at the sailing club and it is absolutely beautiful. And I think it reflects the amount of people that come here to see.

You can have some wonderful experiences and the things that you don't necessarily get these experiences in other parts of the world. Now the Daintree I've been up there myself is absolutely spectacular. You get all the backpackers coming from overseas and really that's their number one choice of where they want to be in Australia, right? Correct.

And look we've got, I mean obviously COVID through a huge spanner in the works for tourism around the world but Australia is doing well. We're seeing them come back and it's been connected to the aviation sector but we in Queensland spent \$200 million attracting airlines back

in. So we're seeing a lot of backpackers which for regional economies they're really important for the tourism and the hospitality as a labour force.

But the other thing is there's lots of work in the agricultural sector and around regional cities. So these young girls and boys that are coming from all over the world, they can live in a regional city for a month or two. They can work, they can work out in the agricultural sector whether they're picking fruit or whether they're assisting in a wide range of other job opportunities.

And then they can travel and that funds their travelling. So it's unique in that sense. It's safe, the weather is spectacular and it's a well trodden path.

So there are a lot of kids that will do this, whether they're from South America, they're from the United or Canada and the US. A lot of Europeans, a lot of Brits, it's fantastic and they form a really important part of our tourism market and our international market. I mean our international tourists, they stay longer, they spend more and they're more likely to have a strong connection.

They want to see an indigenous experience. So when we see that, particularly our European markets, we know there's a strong urge there. So we're making sure that when we're in government, we're investing and we wanted to make sure that everybody was doing well.

Because if regional Queensland is doing well, the state's doing well and inevitably Australia and tourism. Because tourism, I've spent 35, 40 years of my life in the tourism industry before I got into politics. It's a fantastic career and there's some great opportunities and some wonderful products as you know.

We must give a big shout out to the opposition leader, Stephen Miles, for making those fantastic 50 Cent Fairs in South East Queensland, which are really a game changer, aren't they? Absolutely. And one of the things about the 50 Cent Fairs is that we're seeing people change their method of transport. If we can get more people using public transport and less people on our roads, well that's going to be better for the environment.

We have to, we need these game changers and we need to ensure that people can use public transport without, I mean, if you look at it, you go and look at a traffic jam, take a photograph. The amount of cars that have one person in it, you can get four people in a car, but we're not good at doing that. We're not good at doing carpooling.

So those 50 Cent Fairs, we've actually seen, statistically, if my memory serves me correctly, we've seen a reduction in car accidents. But we've seen a lot more people, obviously, using that public transport and therefore, environmentally, it's good for the environment. And these are real game changers.

You've got to push these initiatives and people go, oh well, I wouldn't have usually gone by train or I wouldn't have usually got the ferry or a bus. But by offering that alternative, it works a whole

lot better. And speaking of trains, I've been travelling from Brisbane up here to Gladstone on numerous occasions to visit my family.

And Queensland Rail services are just tremendous, aren't they? And not just along the coast, but inland as well. Correct. Yeah.

And look, there are Queensland Rail does a fantastic job. And as we know, rail experiences around the world are world class. And I would say we have some fantastic world class experiences, whether you're coming up from Brisbane, up to the tropical north, even out in the regional areas.

We've got a wide range of experiences on the rail networks and a lot of them are run as tourism products, particularly up in the Far North Queensland. So getting around is a really good, fun way of doing it. It's a wonderful way to see Western Queensland.

It was part of the foundation of our transport out there. Once we got the horses and the carriage sorted, transport then was rail. And rail, whilst it sort of moved around a little bit, we still have the infrastructure there.

A lot of people are investing in that as our history is part of our heritage. So if you're a rail enthusiast, Queensland and Western Queensland has a wide range of assets out there. We'd love to welcome you on.

Now, Michael Healy, Shadow Tourism Minister here in the beautiful state of Queensland. And now you get around to a lot of places, especially when you're in government. Tell us a couple of your favourite places to hang out in Queensland for those who've never been here.

Well, I can tell you the best place to visit in Queensland, and it's not open to everybody, is my house, where my family is. But I can tell you whether we're talking about the beautiful golden beaches in the southeast, whether we're talking about the Barrier Reef, the southeast, which is down here off Gladstone, whether we're talking about out west, we've got some great dinosaur trails, we've got some fantastic infrastructure in regional Queensland. And then once again, we're heading up to the Cape.

We've got some fantastic indigenous products out there. There really is such a wide range of products. And this is why we've been so successful in getting international tourists and being Australia's number one favoured destination Queensland because we have so many different products.

But I can tell you, you know, last holidays I went down to the southeast so I could go for a surf, and I drove back to Cairns. And along the way, we stopped at a variety, some of the best mango ice cream, our natural produce, our food is fantastic. It forms part of our holiday experience.

There is no bad part. It's just how much time have you got because there is so much. And we've

got some fantastic access.

If you go to the tourism events Queensland website, you'll be able to see the amazing and wide range of outrageous products that we have. And I'll tell you what, the idea when you have your holiday is not only you relax, your family's having a good time, but you walk away informed and you feel just a little bit better about helping out a city or a region, a town or an environment. Michael Healy, the Shadow Tourism Minister, can you say hello to our Travel Radio Australia audience out there on our huge group of radio stations across the country? Well, to everybody out there, I want to say it's fantastic and thank you for this opportunity.

Please, when you can, come to Queensland, get out and have a look at some of our fantastic products. We know how important it is to have tourists here. You'll be well and truly looked after and we'll make sure you have a wonderful experience.

Michael, thank you very much for being on the program. Good man, thanks very much. Thanks, mate.

And all the best, look forward to seeing everyone in Queensland.